

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 49

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A new mother describes the first few hours of bringing her baby home from hospital, and the unexpected arrival of her own mother at the door.

1

The flat was too quiet. That was the first thing I noticed when Daniel pushed the door open with his shoulder and stepped aside to let me through. I had spent five days in a maternity ward where someone was always crying, beeping or briskly drawing a curtain, and now, suddenly, the loudest thing in the world was the small whistling breath of the baby I was holding. I stood in the hallway in my coat, afraid to take another step, as though the floorboards themselves might startle her.

2

Daniel set down the bag with the car seat in it, then the bag with the nappies, then a third bag whose contents I could no longer remember. He looked at me and smiled, and the smile wobbled in a way it had not done at the hospital. “Well,” he said. The word hung in the air. We had said “well” to each other a thousand times before — over kettles, over keys, over takeaway menus — and never, until that moment, had it sounded like a question that neither of us knew how to answer.

3

I carried her into the living room. Everything in it looked unfamiliar, although nothing had moved. The cushions were where I had left them. The mug I had abandoned five days ago, still half full of cold tea, sat in its usual ring on the table. Yet the room felt rearranged at some invisible level, as if all the furniture had quietly shifted an inch to make space for somebody new. I sat down on the edge of the sofa, very slowly, and looked into the small, sleeping face in the crook of my arm. She was, I thought, impossibly light, and at the same time, the heaviest thing I had ever held.

4

Her fingers, which I had counted twice in the hospital and once more in the lift, were curled now around the edge of the blanket. They were the size of matchsticks. I could not stop staring at them. Somewhere, far away, Daniel was making tea and dropping things — a teaspoon, a lid, the kettle’s flex — and

apologising under his breath to nobody in particular. The kitchen sounds, which would normally have annoyed me, were suddenly the most comforting noises in the world. He, too, did not yet know how to walk in our own kitchen without making it strange.

5

A wave of fear came up through my chest then, quite without warning. What if I dropped her. What if I held her wrongly. What if, in the small inattention of a single second, I let something happen. I did not phrase these thoughts as questions, because questions imply that there might be an answer; mine were dark certainties that pressed against the inside of my ribs. I pulled her closer, and the blanket she was wrapped in smelled, already, faintly of milk and of myself, and I did not know whether that frightened me or steadied me.

6

The doorbell rang. Daniel called my name from the kitchen — half a question, half an apology — and I heard him cross the hall. There were voices, low and warm, and then the unmistakable, brisk tread of my mother, who has always walked into other people's houses as though she owned a share in them. She appeared in the doorway with a flask in one hand and a folded muslin cloth in the other, took one quick look at the two of us on the sofa, and put both down without saying anything at all. She sat beside me. She did not reach for the baby. She simply placed one hand, very lightly, on my knee.

7

"I have brought soup," she said at last. "And I have brought a story, but the story can wait." She told it anyway, of course, as I had known she would. It was a story I had heard before — about the night she had brought me home from the same hospital, more than thirty years ago, and how she had sat on the edge of her own sofa and wept, not from sadness, but because she was terrified she would not be enough. I had always thought the story exaggerated. I understood it, now, completely. I felt my shoulders, which I had not realised were rigid, loosen by a single degree.

8

After my mother left, the flat was quiet again, but the quiet was a different quiet. Daniel sat on the floor at my feet, his head against my knee. The baby slept on. I thought, with a clarity that surprised me, that fear and joy would, from this evening on, share the same room — that they were not, in fact, opposites, but companions, and that I would have to learn to set a place for both of them. I held my daughter a little closer, and, for the first time since we had stepped through the door, I was not afraid of the silence.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says "the flat was too quiet." Explain, in your own words, why the quiet feels strange to her at this moment. [2]

2. The narrator stands in the hallway "afraid to take another step, as though the floorboards themselves might startle her." What does this suggest about her state of mind? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says that Daniel's smile "wobbled in a way it had not done at the hospital." What does this tell us about how Daniel is feeling now that they are home? [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says the living room "felt rearranged at some invisible level." Explain what she means by this. [2]

5. The narrator describes her daughter as “impossibly light, and at the same time, the heaviest thing I had ever held.” Explain how this contrast captures her feelings as a new mother. [2]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says that Daniel’s kitchen noises “would normally have annoyed me” but were now “the most comforting noises in the world.” What does this change suggest about her feelings towards Daniel at this moment? [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says her worries were “not... questions” but “dark certainties that pressed against the inside of my ribs.” Explain how the language used here makes her fear seem powerful. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator’s mother “did not reach for the baby” but “simply placed one hand, very lightly, on my knee.” What does this gesture suggest about the mother’s understanding of her daughter? [2]

From Paragraph 7

9. The narrator says that she had “always thought the story exaggerated” but now understood it “completely.” What does this tell us about how her view of her mother has changed? [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says fear and joy “were not, in fact, opposites, but companions.” Explain, in your own words, what she has come to realise about motherhood. [1]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on why birth rates are falling across Asia, and what governments can realistically do about it.

1

A generation ago, the demographic problem of East Asia was thought to be too many children. Family-planning posters in Singapore once urged couples to “Stop at Two”, and similar campaigns ran in South Korea and Taiwan. Today, those posters belong in a museum. South Korea’s total fertility rate fell to 0.72 in 2023, the lowest ever recorded by any country; Japan, Taiwan and Singapore now sit between 1.0 and 1.1, well below the 2.1 needed to replace the existing population. In plain language, the average couple in these places is having barely one child between them. The future of an entire region is being quietly rewritten at the kitchen table.

2

The reasons are layered, and rarely come singly. The most commonly cited is the cost of housing. In Seoul, Tokyo, and Singapore, a young couple may spend the better part of a decade saving for a flat barely large enough for two adults, let alone the cot, the pram and the patient grandparent that a child typically requires. A second reason is work culture. Salaried jobs in much of East Asia still expect long hours, weekend availability, and a polite reluctance to leave the office before the boss. A baby, whose timetable is famously indifferent to corporate convenience, does not fit easily into such a schedule.

3

A third factor — the one that economists are now most willing to discuss aloud — is the penalty paid by women for becoming mothers. Several recent studies estimate that, in Japan and South Korea, a woman’s earnings fall by between thirty and forty per cent in the decade after she has her first child, and never fully recover; men’s earnings, by contrast, are almost unaffected. Faced with this trade-off, an educated woman in her late twenties may quite rationally decide either to delay motherhood or to forgo it altogether. Asia’s falling fertility is not a story of women becoming reluctant; it is a story of women becoming honest about the price they are asked to pay.

4

There is also the quieter matter of changing values. The young adults of Tokyo, Taipei and Singapore have grown up watching their parents work themselves tired, and many have concluded that the trade involved — a steady salary in exchange for one’s twenties and thirties — is not, on reflection, a good one. They wish to travel, to take career risks, to live alone for a while before they live with anyone else. None of this is irresponsible. It is, in fact, the predictable result of higher education, urban living and the slow, polite retreat of arranged matchmaking.

5

Governments have noticed, and have responded with money. South Korea has spent, by one estimate, more than 270 billion US dollars on pro-natal schemes since 2006. Singapore offers a Baby Bonus, generous parental leave, and tax reliefs that escalate cheerfully with each additional child. Japan has tried subsidised childcare; Taiwan has tried direct cash. The results, almost everywhere, have been disappointing. Fertility rates have continued to fall. The reason, in the view of most demographers, is brutally simple: cash cannot compensate for time, energy and career security that the wider economy still refuses to offer. A subsidy is a small consolation against a thirty-year decision.

6

The long-run consequences are already beginning to show. A country whose fertility rate stays near 1.0 will, within a single generation, see its working-age population shrink dramatically. Schools will close. Universities will merge. The tax base that funds pensions and hospitals will narrow, even as the number of elderly citizens needing those pensions and hospitals widens. Japan, which began this journey earliest,

already has whole rural villages with no children at all and a fast-growing shortage of nurses, geriatric carers and even funeral directors. South Korea is following on the same path, only faster.

7

What might realistically help? Honest analysts now agree that no single policy will reverse the trend; the change is too deep and too cultural for that. Useful responses are likely to come in clusters. Affordable family-sized housing must be built, not merely promised. Workplaces must be made to treat parents — both parents — as normal employees rather than awkward exceptions. Childcare must be high quality and genuinely accessible. And the wider culture, including the rest of us, must stop treating the decision to have a child as either a private hobby or a national obligation, and start treating it as what it plainly is: a shared and very ordinary act of hope.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the old family-planning posters “belong in a museum.” Explain, in your own words, what this suggests about how attitudes towards population have changed. [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, what is meant by saying that the future of the region is “being quietly rewritten at the kitchen table”? [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. The writer says that a baby’s “timetable is famously indifferent to corporate convenience.” Explain what this phrase means and what it suggests about work culture in East Asia. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says that “Asia’s falling fertility is not a story of women becoming reluctant; it is a story of women becoming honest about the price they are asked to pay.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. According to Paragraph 4, give **two** changes in values among young adults that have contributed to falling birth rates. [2]

17. The writer says that the choices of young adults are “the predictable result of higher education, urban living and the slow, polite retreat of arranged matchmaking.” What does the word **predictable** suggest about the writer’s view of the trend? [1]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that “cash cannot compensate for time, energy and career security.” Explain, in your own words, why government cash payments have been so ineffective. [2]

19. What is the **tone** of the phrase “A subsidy is a small consolation against a thirty-year decision”? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. According to Paragraph 6, give **two** long-run consequences for a country whose fertility rate stays near 1.0. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says that having a child should be treated as “a shared and very ordinary act of hope.” Explain what is **effective** about this final phrase. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the main reasons why birth rates are falling across Asia**, and **the consequences of this decline**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Birth rates in Asia are falling because ...

— END OF PAPER —